

Pre Illinois State Game: Will Cats eat Birds?

This Wednesday, February 25th, at 6 pm central, UNI will take on the Illinois State Redbirds in the McLeod Center. This game is shaping up to be a tooth and nail fight. This will be the fight to secure 5th place in the Missouri Valley Conference. Both teams have a conference win record of 10-8 and an overall win record of 18-11. Beyond just the win records, both of these teams are evenly matched. According to ESPN Basketball stats, the Redbirds, on average, score 75.9 points per game, while the Panthers score 69.1 points per game on average. For points against, Redbirds have 68.0, and the Panthers have 61.1. Both of their Field Goal Percentages are 47%. These are only a few key stats. As you can see, both teams are evenly matched. Despite their stats being almost the same, ESPN's Matchup Predictor predicts UNI will win over the Redbirds at a 66.8% chance. This is above 50%, but that doesn't mean it will be an easy game. The top scorer for the Panthers is #4 Trey Campbell with 13.3 points per game on average. The top scorer for the Redbirds is #35 Chase Walker with 13.7 points per game on average. Make sure to tune in or get your tickets. This will be a very tough game for both teams.

Post Illinois State Game: Panthers lose hard fought game to Illinois State

3,907 people showed up to the McLeod Center for Wednesday's game between the visiting Illinois State Redbirds and the home UNI Panthers was a close one from tip-off to the final buzzer. Despite the hard-fought game, UNI lost 69 to 71. Over the course of the game, there were 16 lead changes with a maximum of 8 points for a lead. Of these 16 lead changes, 12 of them took place in the last 10 minutes of the game. But let's go back to the start to see how UNI lost this game.

The game opened with the Redbirds' Mason Klabo scoring 3 with the assist from Chase Walker. This led the Redbirds to hold the lead for the first quarter of the game. UNI would then take the lead at 6:50 with Leon Bond III making a 2-point layup with the assistance of Tristan Smith. This started a very good run for Smith. Shortly after the 2-point layup, he made another 2-point layup. He also had 2 rebounds. However, at the end of the 1st he incurred a foul. This allowed the Redbird's Jack Daugherty to make 3 free throw attempts. Daugherty managed to make all of them despite UNI calling a timeout just before Daugherty threw his last free throw. This resulted in the first half ending 28 to 23, Panthers down. This foul set the mood for Smith's second half. During the second half, Smith would miss both of his free throw attempts and incur 2 more fouls. These fouls resulted in only 1 more point for the Redbirds, but 1 point would have made a difference in a game this close.

While Smith was struggling in the second half, the rest of the Panthers were on a roll. During the second half, UNI scored 46 points, double what they scored in the first half. The second half opened with Max Weisbrod making a 3-point shot with the assistance of Will Hornseth. This, unfortunately, was quickly followed by Chase Walker making a layup for the Redbirds, keeping a lead of 4 points. The Redbirds would keep this lead till Trey Campbell made a layup with 14:13 left in the half. The Panthers kept this lead until there were 7:35 left in the half. This is when the lead kept being switched back and forth. The game would ultimately end in a loss for UNI when the Redbird's Johnny Kinziger scored 2-points and was awarded 2 free throws due to a foul on Bond III. While Kinziger only made 1 of his free throws, it was enough to win them the game.

Overall, this game was a good one. There was competition the entire time, and never a dull moment. Looking over some final game stats, let's see where these teams stood. Starting with Field Goal percentages, UNI made 50% of their field goal attempts while the Redbirds made 49% of theirs. This is not surprising when you look at the score. Out of UNI's 48 attempts, 16 were for 3-point shots. UNI made 56% of their 3-point attempts. This is somewhat surprising until you realize that the Redbirds made more attempts overall than the Panthers. The Redbirds also had a total of 32 rebounds during the game. For turnovers, the Redbirds had 12 while the Panthers only had 8. This shows that the Panthers kept onto the ball better and played better defense. Another notable stat was that of fouls. We talked about how Smith made several fouls, but this does not mean UNI had the most fouls. The Redbirds managed to accrue 20 fouls, while the Panthers managed 12. Of these 20 fouls on the Redbirds, many were for traveling. I haven't seen that much traveling in a long time. The last team stat I'll mention is lead percentage. The Redbirds managed to keep the lead for 53% of the game. Not that surprising when they won.

Regarding player stats, let's start with the highest scorer for both teams. Starting with the Redbirds, Ben Skunberg and Johnny Kinziger both scored 14 points. For the Panthers there was a 3 way tie at 13 points scored, Will Hornseth, Ben Schwieger, and Trey Campbell. Campbell and Bond III made all of their free throws. Campbell with 5 and Bond with 3.

An interesting thing I noticed while watching the game was that UNI didn't seem to be subbing many people in. When looking at the stats UNI had their starters play most of the game, with only 29 minutes given to their bench players, Smith, Kyle Pock, Geon Hutchins, and RJ Taylor. The Redbirds, on the other hand, gave 63 minutes to their bench players, Jack Daugherty, Brandon Lieb, Ty'reek Coleman, Ty Pence, and Landon Moore. I wonder if UNI subbed in more players or at least let their bench players play for longer, if this could have helped with fatigue. If fatigue was an issue that is.

There are many ways this game could have gone. It would have been nice for a UNI win but with how hard they fought, I have no doubt that the next games, especially the tournament, will be just as entertaining. I am looking forward to seeing what the Panthers do next. If given the chance to face Illinois State again, will they win? They almost did this time.

Outlook for the MVC Arch Madness Tournament

UNI has one final game of the regular season. This game is on Sunday, March 1st at Drake in Des Moines, Iowa. This game is not likely to change UNI's standing in the Missouri Valley Conference for the Arch Madness Tournament. This is because Drake is already ranked lower than UNI at 9th. Therefore, there is little chance for UNI to rise in the standings. Currently, UNI is 7th in the conference. This means they will play the first day of the tournament Thursday, March 5th. However, this can change due to the season not being over. There are still games to play, which means standings can change as well. Just this week, UNI dropped from 6th to 7th place and Valparaiso rose to 6th. Only time will tell where UNI ends up. However, I think it's safe to say that UNI will be playing on the first day of the tournament, Thursday March 5th. This means that the Panthers have a long and hard path ahead of them if they want to reach the finals for Arch Madness. But hard doesn't mean impossible. UNI has the potential to go far in the tournament this year. But as I said, time will tell.